Jacob Grimm — Deutsche Grammatik (1819–1837)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 14 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the subject reviewers are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

This edition is dedicated to Jacob Grimm (1785–1863), whose *Deutsche Grammatik*, published in four volumes between 1819 and 1837, first described the historical phonology, morphology, and simple sentence syntax of all the Germanic languages. In the revision of 1822 it set out what became known as Grimm's Law, the pattern of sound change that bears his name. The dossier calls the work, with a deliberate qualification, arguably the founding document of historical linguistics, the study of how languages change. The dedication honours a grammar of that scale which remains famous by reputation and by extracts, while no more than a fraction of it has ever appeared in English.

The story

Jacob Grimm (1785–1863) wrote a grammar unlike the grammars that had come before it. His *Deutsche Grammatik*, published in four volumes between 1819 and 1837, first described the historical phonology, morphology, and simple sentence syntax of all the Germanic languages. In plain words, it traced how their sounds had changed over time, how their words were formed, and how their simplest sentences were built. In the revision of 1822 it set out what became known as Grimm's Law, the pattern of sound change that bears his name.

The dossier calls the work, with a deliberate qualification, arguably the founding document of historical linguistics — the study of how languages change. That scale is what makes its English history so striking. A founding work can be famous, cited, and taught, and still remain largely unavailable in English. Grimm's grammar is famous in exactly that incomplete way: known by reputation and by extracts, but not present as a complete English book that a reader can work through volume by volume.

This dossier also begins with a correction, and the correction matters to the story. James Steven Stallybrass did not translate the *Deutsche Grammatik*, in whole or in part. Stallybrass translated a different book by Grimm, the *Deutsche Mythologie*, as *Teutonic Mythology*, in four volumes published between 1880 and 1888, and he translated that work completely. The *Grammatik* was never his. Keeping the two books separate is the first act of honesty in presenting this one.

The work and what survives

The German original was published between 1819 and 1837, with a second revised edition published between 1822 and 1837. It is in the public domain everywhere.

Internet Archive scans, digitised by Google, are identified in the record: volume 1 in its third edition, under the identifier `bub_gb_VXTJ_C205t4C`; volumes 2–3 as a set, under `bub_gb_Z3MJAAAAQAAJ`; volume 1 in its second edition, under `deutschegrammati01grim_0`; and volume 3, under `deutschegrammati03grim`. A copy at the MDZ was not confirmed in the review pass. The record is explicit on that point: do not cite MDZ until it is pinned.

Its English fortunes

A scholarly study of the work's British reception states plainly that no more than a fraction of the *Deutsche Grammatik* has ever appeared in English.

The fractions found are these. Hensleigh Wedgwood published an extract and review in the *Quarterly Review* in 1833. Selections later appeared in Winfred P. Lehmann, editor, *A Reader in Nineteenth-Century Historical Indo-European Linguistics*, published in 1967.

Beyond those fractions, the bounded finding is this: no English translation of

volumes 2–4, and no complete English translation of volume 1, found after research.

What completing it would take

This is a multi-year, multi-volume undertaking, and the dossier does not present it as a quick completion. The realistic first unit is volume 1 of the 1822 second edition — the Grimm's Law volume — translated whole. That single volume, on the record here, would alone exceed everything currently in English combined.

The work pairs with the Delbrück syntax dossier in this collection, as a programme in Germanic and Indo-European philology in two parts: Grimm on the history of the Germanic languages, Delbrück on comparative syntax.

Sources

- https://www.thefreelibrary.com/Misrepresentation+in+Hensleigh+Wedgwood%27s+review+of+Jacob+Grimm%27s...-a015886690 (reception study; the "fraction" statement)
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Grimm%27s_law
- https://www.mimisbrunnr.info/grimmdex (Stallybrass = *Mythologie*, not *Grammatik*)
- https://archive.org/details/bub_gb_VXTJ_C205t4C · https://archive.org/details/bub_gb_Z3MJAAAAQAAJ · https://archive.org/details/deutschegrammati03grim